

Kathua, about 80 km short of Jammu. The attempt to complete the line all the way to Jammu continued through the 1960s, slowing down considerably because of the 1971 Indo-Pakistan war. It finally opened to passenger traffic in December 1972. Work continues today to connect Delhi and Kashmir (see [Kashmir Connection](#)).

Rajasthan was another region that saw key railway construction for military and strategic reasons. A rail link to Jaisalmer, a sprawling town in the heart of the Thar Desert at the edge of the India–Pakistan border, had always been under consideration. It became a matter of importance after the 1965 Indo-Pakistan war and work began in full swing in 1966. The 106-km-long Pokhran–Jaisalmer link opened a year later in 1967. The 233-km-long Jhund–Kandla, later Gandhidham, line in the Saurashtra region of Gujarat opened in 1969. A section crosses the quicksands of the Rann of Kutch via a 6-km-long bridge. The line was built to reduce the load on the Bombay port and railways after Partition and also increase connectivity to the Kandla port, an important hub for import and export traffic.

Another significant line constructed at this time was the Khandwa–Hingoli project that ran through the states of Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra, crossing the Satpura, Melghat, and Ajanta hill ranges. The line crosses four rivers, including the Tapti. Construction through Melghat was particularly treacherous with one section of the line making a complete spiral in order to gain height. It integrated the metre-gauge sections of western and southern India.